

CORE FORMULA

Cue + soft marker + optional invitation + room. -> You said you left pretty suddenly. If you're comfortable sharing, what led up to that? -> You lit up when you mentioned that project. How did that start? -> That sounds like a real turning point. What changed for you there? -> Only if it's not too much to get into, what's the story behind that?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Notice a genuine story cue, offer one warm, low-pressure invitation - "What's the story behind that?" - then stay quiet and let them choose how much to tell.

BEST FOR

- Someone mentions a change, decision, unusual preference, strong reaction, or turning point.
- A conversation is stuck at surface level but has a clear cue for depth.
- A professional conversation needs context before advice, negotiation, or planning.
- A social conversation would benefit from warmth and personal texture.
- Someone seems willing to say more but has not yet found the invitation.

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Default one-line invitations

- "What's the story behind that?"
- "What led up to that?"
- "How did that unfold?"
- "How did you end up there?"
- "What's the backstory there?"
- "What changed for you there?"
- "How did that start?"
- "What was the first thing that shifted?"

Social & rapport · Hobbies, passions, life texture

- "How did that become a thing for you?"
- "What got you into that?"
- "What was the moment you realised that?"
- "Sounds like there's a lot behind that - how did it come about?"
- "What pulled you towards that in the first place?"
- "There's probably a story there. What was it like?"
- "What are you like when you're really into something?"

Work & decisions · Context before advice or planning

- "What led to that decision?"
- "What was the path that got the team there?"
- "What changed between the old approach and this one?"
- "Can you walk me through how that developed?"
- "What context would help me understand that better?"
- "What context should I understand before I respond?"
- "Before we plan, what's the short version of how we got here?"

Direct invitations · Plain, un-softened asks

- "What happened there?"
- "How did you land on that?"
- "What changed your mind on that?"
- "What's the main sequence, from the top?"
- "Walk me through it - where did it start?"
- "What was going on around then?"

Permission-first (sensitive) · Sensitive cues, permission + release

- "Only if you want to go into it, what led up to that?"
- "Only if it's not too much to get into, what's the story behind that?"
- "We can stay practical, but is there a short version of how we got here?"
- "You don't have to go into personal detail - what's the main sequence?"
- "Only if it feels okay to say, what changed for you then?"
- "If you're comfortable sharing, what led up to that?"
- "Would it be okay to ask how that came about?"

Recovery & release · Softening if it doesn't land

- "No need to go into it - I was just curious about the context."
- "We can leave it there. Thanks for the headline."
- "Is there a story there, or is it not one for now?"
- "We can keep it high level if that's easier."
- "No pressure either way."
- "Let me ask a more practical version - what should I know before responding?"

Digital & async · Text and message-friendly

- "Curious, what led up to that? No pressure if it's a long story."
- "Would be interested in the backstory if you feel like sharing."
- "What's the short version of how that came about?"
- "Happy to hear the longer version whenever suits."
- "I'm curious about the path, but only if it's comfortable."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Why did you do that?" - sounds like a challenge and invites defence.
Better: "What happened?" - open, but can sound abrupt or investigative.
Best: "That sounds like it had a bit of a path behind it. What led up to it?" - marks the cue, lowers pressure, invites a sequence.
2. Weak: "Tell me the whole story." - makes the person perform and assumes access.
Better: "What's the backstory?" - conversational, but can still feel nosy.
Best: "Only if you want to go into it, what's the backstory there?" - preserves choice and offers a clean exit.
3. Weak: "When exactly did that happen?" - jumps to facts before narrative.
Better: "How did it start?" - invites the sequence.
Best: "What was the first thing that shifted?" - narrows gently to the beginning without interrogating.

DECISION TREE

If They gave no story cue.

Don't force it. Stay with warm presence, a contextual opener, or a simple question.
"What's on your mind with this one?"

If There's a cue, but the setting isn't private enough.

Use a high-level version that asks for context, not disclosure.
"What context should I understand before I respond?"

If The cue is sensitive or possibly painful.

Add permission and a clean release before inviting.

"Only if you want to go there - what led up to that?"

If The cue is open and low-stakes.

Offer a direct story invitation, then stop talking.

"Sounds like there's a bit behind that. What led up to it?"

If They open up.

Listen, track the sequence, use minimal encouragers, then reflect the meaning back.

"So it wasn't just the team - it was the pattern of shifting scope."

If They stay brief or withdraw.

Release the pressure and shift to something lighter.

"No need to go into it. I appreciate the headline."

SCENARIOS

A friend mentions a life change

Mark the cue, add permission, and reflect the turning point rather than every detail. — "Sounds like there was a lot behind that. Only if you want to, what led up to the move?"

A colleague mentions a decision

Ask for the sequence, then listen for constraints and decision criteria. — "What led to that decision?"

A new contact mentions a passion

Notice the enthusiasm and ask one light continuation. — "How did that become a thing for you?"

A customer mentions a recurring frustration

Stay practical and ask for the pattern without assigning blame. — "To understand the pattern, what led up to this from your side?"

A family member hints at a sensitive topic

Offer maximum permission and accept any level of answer. — "Only if it feels okay to say, what changed for you then?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They have signalled they do not want to talk about it.
- The topic is visibly painful and you do not have enough trust or time.
- The setting is public and the answer could expose them.
- You need a direct operational fact, not a narrative.
- You are asking mainly to satisfy curiosity, gossip, or control the conversation.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency response takes priority.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cues

Write ten surface statements that imply a story ("I changed careers", "I don't go there anymore", "That project taught me a lot") and underline the story cue in each.

Day 2 — Three versions

For each cue, write one blunt fact question, one acceptable question, and one story invitation. Notice how the invitation lands differently from the interrogation.

Day 3 — Add permission

Take your five most sensitive cues and add a permission softener to each ("only if you want to go into it", "if you're comfortable sharing").

Day 4 — Invite, then wait

Say each invitation out loud once, then stay silent for a full three seconds. Get comfortable letting the silence do the work instead of adding a second question.

Day 5 — Live, low-stakes

In a real conversation, wait for one genuine cue, offer a single story invitation, then stop and just listen to whatever comes back.

Day 6 — Calibrate live

Across today's conversations, practise reading the response - open, brief, or resistant - and choose continue, reflect, or release accordingly.

Day 7 — Recover cleanly

Rehearse the recovery lines until they sound plain, then use one for real when an invitation doesn't land, releasing the pressure without over-apologising.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I wait for a real cue before inviting the story?
- Did my tone sound curious rather than suspicious?
- Did I ask one clean invitation instead of stacking questions?
- Did I give the person room to choose the depth?
- Did I release the pressure if the invitation didn't land?
- Did I listen to the story rather than hunting for my next question?